

SYNTH-01: Synthetic Monitoring Fundamentals

Series: SYNTH — Synthetic Monitoring | **Notebook:** 1 of 6 | **Created:** December 2025 | **Last Updated:** 04/26/2026

Understanding Proactive Availability and Performance Testing

This notebook introduces Dynatrace Synthetic Monitoring, which enables proactive testing of application availability, functionality, and performance from locations around the world.

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Prerequisites

-  Access to a Dynatrace environment with Synthetic Monitoring enabled
-  DQL query permissions (viewer role minimum)
-  Basic understanding of web applications and APIs

Sprint 1.337 (April 2026) Updates

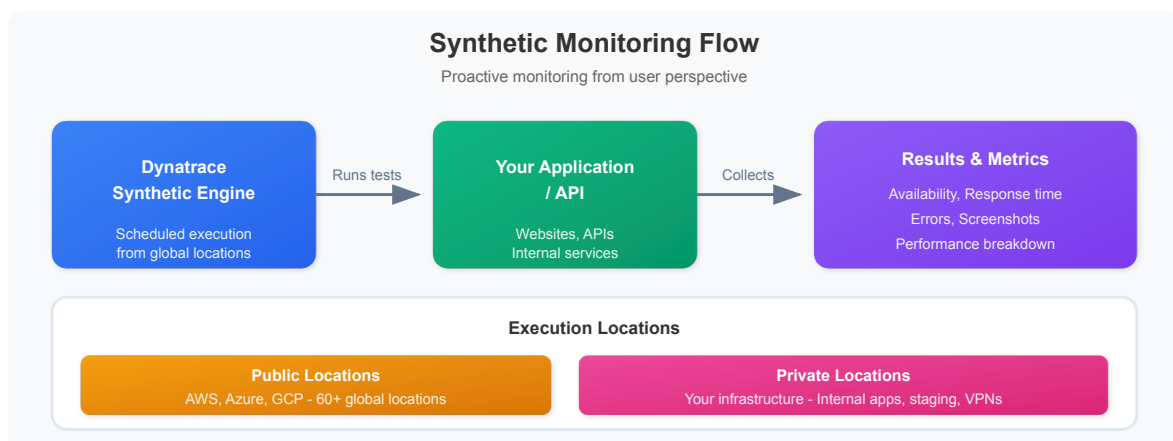
Two sprint-1.337 changes touch synthetic monitoring:

- **OneAgent primary fields/tags at the source** (Latest Dynatrace) — when synthetic monitors are paired with private-location ActiveGates running on monitored hosts (SYNTH-04), the host's primary tags ride on synthetic execution metadata. Useful for cost-attribution dashboards that want to bill synthetic execution by team or product line.
- **Configuration API → Settings v2 + Platform tokens** for new automation. Synthetic monitor management via Terraform/Monaco should target Settings v2 (`builtin:synthetic_test`) — note the v1.88.0 Terraform provider boundary still requires API tokens for synthetic monitors specifically (see AUTOM-04 § Authentication Boundary).

1. What is Synthetic Monitoring?

Synthetic Monitoring simulates user interactions with your applications from external locations, providing:

- **Proactive Detection:** Find issues before real users encounter them
- **24/7 Availability Testing:** Monitor even when no users are active
- **Global Performance Baseline:** Measure response times from multiple locations
- **SLA Validation:** Verify service level agreements are being met
- **Third-Party Dependency Monitoring:** Test external APIs and services



Synthetic vs Real User Monitoring (RUM)

Aspect	Synthetic Monitoring	Real User Monitoring
Data Source	Simulated transactions	Actual user sessions
Coverage	24/7, consistent	Only when users active
Locations	Controlled, specific	Wherever users are
Use Case	Baseline, SLA, proactive	Actual experience
Cost	Per execution	Per session

2. Monitor Types

Dynatrace offers three types of synthetic monitors:

Browser Monitors (Single-URL and Browser Clickpath)

Type	Description	Use Case
Single-URL	Load a single page	Homepage availability
Browser Clickpath	Multi-step user journey	Login flows, checkout

Capabilities:

- Full browser rendering (Chrome)
- JavaScript execution
- Visual validation (screenshots)
- Performance metrics (W3C timing)
- Resource waterfall analysis

HTTP Monitors

Type	Description	Use Case
Single Request	One HTTP call	API health check
Multi-step	Chained requests	API workflow validation

Capabilities:

- Any HTTP method (GET, POST, PUT, DELETE)
- Custom headers and authentication
- Response validation (status, content, JSON)
- SSL certificate monitoring
- Lightweight and fast execution

Third-Party Monitors

Integration with external synthetic providers:

- Catchpoint
- Pingdom
- Site24x7

3. Key Concepts

Execution Locations

Location Type	Description	Best For
Public	Dynatrace-hosted worldwide	External-facing apps
Private	Your infrastructure	Internal apps, security

Execution Frequency

How often the monitor runs:

- **Browser:** 5, 10, 15, 30, 60 minutes
- **HTTP:** 1, 5, 10, 15, 30, 60 minutes

Outage Detection

Dynatrace detects outages based on:

- Consecutive failures from single location
- Failures from multiple locations simultaneously
- Local outage vs global outage classification

Key Metrics

Metric	Description	Monitor Type
availability	Success rate (%)	All
responseTime	Total execution time	All
dnsTime	DNS lookup duration	HTTP, Browser
connectTime	TCP connection time	HTTP, Browser
sslTime	SSL handshake time	HTTP, Browser
ttfb	Time to first byte	HTTP, Browser
visuallyComplete	Visual rendering complete	Browser
speedIndex	Visual progress score	Browser

4. Synthetic Data in Grail

Synthetic execution data is stored in Grail and queryable via DQL:

Data Tables

Table	Description
dt.entity.synthetic_test	Monitor definitions
dt.entity.synthetic_location	Execution locations
dt.entity.http_check	HTTP monitor entities
dt.entity.browser_monitor	Browser monitor entities

Key Fields

Field	Description
dt.entity.synthetic_test	Monitor entity ID
dt.entity.synthetic_location	Location entity ID

Field	Description
<code>synthetic.monitor.name</code>	Monitor display name
<code>synthetic.location.name</code>	Location display name
<code>synthetic.execution.id</code>	Unique execution identifier
<code>synthetic.availability</code>	Success (true/false)
<code>synthetic.response_time</code>	Execution duration (ms)

5. Your First Synthetic Query

Let's explore synthetic monitoring data in your environment.

```
// Discover synthetic monitors in your environment
// Note: Monitor type and enabled status are not available as entity fields
// Use bizevents to see execution details by monitor type
fetch dt.entity.synthetic_test
| fields id, entity.name
| sort entity.name asc
| limit 50
```

```
// Count monitors by event type (from execution data)
// Since entity 'type' field is not available, we count from bizevents
fetch bizevents, from: now() - 24h
| filter event.provider == "dynatrace.synthetic"
| summarize {count = count()}, by: {event.type}
| sort count desc
```

```
// List available synthetic locations
// Note: cloudPlatform, city, countryCode fields are not available on
synthetic_location entity
fetch dt.entity.synthetic_location
| fields id, entity.name
| sort entity.name asc
| limit 50
```

```
// Query synthetic execution results (last 24 hours)
fetch bizevents, from: now() - 24h
| filter event.provider == "dynatrace.synthetic"
| fields timestamp,
    event.type,
    synthetic_test_name = dt.entity.synthetic_test,
    location = dt.entity.synthetic_location,
    availability = toDouble(synthetic.availability),
    response_time = toDouble(synthetic.response_time)
| sort timestamp desc
| limit 100
```

```
// Synthetic availability summary (last 24 hours)
fetch bizevents, from: now() - 24h
| filter event.provider == "dynatrace.synthetic"
| summarize {
    total_executions = count(),
    successful = countIf(synthetic.availability == true),
    failed = countIf(synthetic.availability == false)
}
| fieldsAdd availability_pct = round((successful * 100.0) / total_executions,
decimals: 2)
```

```
// Response time by monitor (last 24 hours)
fetch bizevents, from: now() - 24h
| filter event.provider == "dynatrace.synthetic"
| filter isNotNull(synthetic.response_time)
| summarize {
    avg_response_ms = avg(toDouble(synthetic.response_time)),
    max_response_ms = max(toDouble(synthetic.response_time)),
    executions = count()
}, by: {dt.entity.synthetic_test}
| sort avg_response_ms desc
| limit 20
```

Summary

In this notebook, you learned:

- ✅ **What Synthetic Monitoring is** and how it differs from RUM
- ✅ **Monitor types** - Browser (single-URL, clickpath) and HTTP monitors

- ✓ **Key concepts** - Locations, frequency, outage detection
 - ✓ **Grail data model** - Entity tables and execution fields
 - ✓ **Basic DQL queries** - Discover monitors, locations, and results
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Next Steps

Continue to **SYNTH-02: Browser Monitors** to learn how to create and optimize browser-based synthetic tests.

References

- [Synthetic Monitoring Overview](#)
 - [Browser Monitors](#)
 - [HTTP Monitors](#)
 - [Synthetic Locations](#)
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This notebook was AI-generated from community-submitted and publicly available sources. This notebook series is not officially supported by Dynatrace. Always verify information against official Dynatrace documentation.